normalizing terrorism must continue to be resisted vigorously. We must ensure a brand differentiation between two neighbours who each produce their own brand of IT graduates: one on information technology, and the other on international terrorism.

Security has many dimensions, and promoting socio-economic development is one whose worth is increasingly appreciated. As its impact is felt more deeply, challenges diminish accordingly. India is now seriously focussed on achieving its SDG targets. Precisely because the benefits are so self-evident, there are also ongoing attempts to obstruct development and delay progress. The resistance to road-building in Left Wing Extremism (LWE)-affected areas is one obvious example. But if national prospects are undermined or border area infrastructure paralysed, then it is a worry of an even greater magnitude. As the record shows, this can come in many forms and appearances, some openly negative while others take the cover of public good. While noting the centrality of these endeavours to our prospects, it is imperative that we give due priority to ensuring uninterrupted progress.

The digital domain has a special resonance when it comes to development, especially after the Covid experience. Passport issual was an early field of change, but we can now see that governance itself has undergone a transformation. Given the enormous Indian digital market, it is natural that there is a competition in harvesting the data generated. Smart networks and services in different areas are also a subject of contests. Sensitivity to protecting digital services and data is obviously not unique to India. Like many others, we, too, are evaluating the vulnerabilities enhanced by new technologies. India’s endeavour is to find the optimal landing ground that addresses its multiple concerns. These include data protection for citizens, making it easier to do business, ensuring the public interest of efficient governance and safeguarding national security.

A similar sensitivity to telecommunications was a much-awaited step. It will encourage a broader effort to make our security outlook more contemporary. Health security was another important revelation from the Covid experience. Today, we may be exporters of many products and, indeed, a key producer of vaccines. But none of this should obscure the danger of a large society like India depending on others for basic needs. The attitude of states at a time of extreme stress offers lessons that we ignore at